Writing to a fellow playwright, Anton Chekhov had famously advised, "One must never place a loaded gun on the stage if it isn't going to go off. It's wrong to make promises you don't mean to keep." With *Villainy*, Upamanyu Chatterjee has written a novel that would, perhaps, leave Chekhov satisfied. There are, of course, the guns that all go off—suddenly, sometimes fatally—but more importantly, all of *Villainy's* parts contribute to a larger whole—the examination of evil and its many manifestations.

Though *Villainy* starts like so many thrillers do—with a dead body—Chatterjee refuses to reduce the corpse to cliché. Rather than its history, he concerns himself more with the body's handling—its *panchnama* and post-mortem. For the book's first 35 pages, we follow procedure more than we do narrative. Around the time he was writing his 2006 novel, *Weight Loss*, Chatterjee remembers, "I had read somewhere that the number of unidentified bodies found in India is incredibly large. I found sad the thought of all these bodies being abandoned. It seemed extremely important to talk about it."

As Chatterjee sat down to detail the manner in which unidentified corpses are disposed, he also found himself beginning to construct a wider arc: "Once that madcap character was created, he ran away with the rest of the book." Pukhraj Saraf, Chatterjee's "madcap character", has a kind of wanton, manic energy that leaves the book's plot, its people and its readers all unsettled. Son of a prosperous jeweller, the teenaged Pukhraj steals from his father everything he desires—money, a Mercedes, loaded firearms. When paired with Ecstasy and alcohol, we do feel almost certain there will be blood.

The horrific crimes that Pukhraj goes on to commit are defined not by callousness but his cruelty. Even though Parmatma, his driver Atmaram's son, is his only friend in the world, Pukhraj seems more than happy to see him framed for misdeeds he was only ever witness to. Much of *Villainy* sees Pukhraj and his father Nemichand throw money at their problems, while Parmatma and Atmaram are left with only their wits as defence. The fate of these two father-son duos soon catalyses the action of the book.

Speaking to us from Delhi, Chatterjee says that even while none of his four major characters is without blemish, Atmaram and Parmatma do still seem to behave in an exemplary fashion when compared to Nemichand and Pukhraj. He says, "People in the book all become villains for different reasons. Some of them, like the chauffeur and his son, become villains by force of circumstance, but Pukhraj is one because of neglected upbringing. His parents are just horrendously class-conscious, dreadful people."

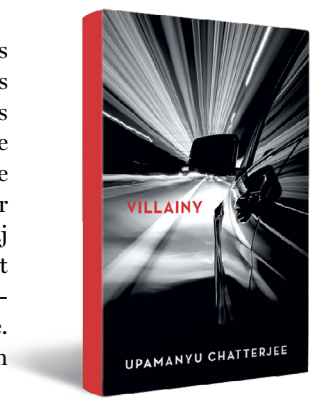
Even as Nemichand Saraf's brutal abuse of his wife and casual exploitation of his driver can, at times, seem excessive, Chatterjee insists that neither the jeweller nor any other character in *Villainy* is exceptional: "Nemichand is making money and avoiding taxes. None of them is out of a Dostoevsky novel. They are just ordinary people, neighbours you meet on your morning walk." Evil, Chatterjee appears to be suggesting, is not something that exists elsewhere; it's closer home than we imagine.

Reading *Villainy* can sometimes feel claustrophobic. Unlike his dark comedies—*Weight Loss* and *Way to Go*, for example—this thriller never pretends to offer consolation. Chatterjee's unrelenting focus on crime and its consequence leaves no room for relief or redemption. Besides, "the idea of redemption is in itself very Christian," says the author. "In India, ethics and morality are completely divorced from religion, from the idea of the spirit." This separation allows even the most pious of Chatterjee's characters the freedom to do wrong with impunity. While Ghazal, Pukhraj's mother, visits temples on the one hand, she freely shoplifts on the other. A corrupt judge is seen drinking *gomutra*.

With chunks of the novel unfolding in courtrooms and prison cells, Chatterjee often maps for us the terribly long distance a bribe or two can traverse. Though he insists he wanted to offer his readers "a rattling good read" more than he did "scathing social commentary", his almost fastidious attention to detail makes it hard to look away from the glaring inefficacies of both our judicial and penal systems. When writing *Villainy*, Chatterjee, a retired IAS officer, went to his friends in the police force with several questions about FIRs, bodies and legal procedure. "Maybe because of my years in government, I find all that very interesting, and I also definitely feel that all this is totally ignored by crime writers."

Despite its twists, Chatterjee never wanted *Villainy* to be "a book about shocking revelations". He says he wanted it to be "realistic" instead. It wasn't enough to simply send Pukhraj and Parmatma to jail, he wanted to know what happened when Nemichand turned up to grease every palm in sight. "And since the book is set in a time period [1997-2016] where you had everyone from Charles Sobhraj and Subrata Roy going in and coming out, I wanted to suggest that whole aura of major and minor villainy around them. I wanted to do that without moralising or saying how awful the world is."

Even though Chatterjee never makes ex-



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